

Dear Reader,

It's hard to put a single label on Leonardo da Vinci: painter, sculptor, engineer, architect, philosopher—he was all of these things. Yet even when taken together, it is possible that something is still missing. Maybe it's simply the genius that allowed him to master so many professions at once.

Leonardo lived in an age of political, economic, and cultural upheaval, but he tried to sidestep the turbulence of his times to focus on his art. "The evil that does not harm me," he wrote, most likely referring to his even temperament, "is as the good that does not help me." As famous as Leonardo became for the works he completed, he was almost as well-known for the projects that he either abandoned, left unfinished, or never found time to fully explore.

More than anything, Leonardo wanted to pursue his dreams and follow his curiosities—wherever they might lead him. The fact that he was able to do that over so much of his life may have meant more to him than the towering achievements that have endured in his name.

Stephen Krensky

